Saying No Politely

A Polite No Has Three Parts

Say you are sorry — I'm sorry..., I'd really like to, but..., I appreciate the offer, but...

Explain why the answer is no — I'm really busy right now, We aren't free that weekend...

Offer an alternative — I might be able to next week, John might be able to help...

Saying No to a Request

I'd love to help you, but right now I'm really busy with...

I wish I could, but right now I need to focus on...

Normally I'd be able to, but right now I have to...

Saying No to an Offer

I appreciate the offer, but...

That would be great, but I'm already working on...

Thank you for the offer, but my schedule is full at the moment.

Saying No to an Invitation

That sounds great, but...

I'm sorry, I can't make that night. I have to...

I really appreciate the invite, but...

Practice

A coworker asks you out for drinks on Friday. You don't drink and don't like bars.

Just as you leave for lunch, a coworker asks you to review some financial documents first.

A former client calls and wants to hire you again. You are busy and don't want the job.

Mike asks you to join a conference call to help him close a sale. You have no time to help.

Two coworkers ask you to join the company softball team. You would rather be with your family.

An acquaintance who just started a business wants you to design his website. You don't think it is worth your time.

Discussion

Has anyone ever offended you by accident? How?

Have you ever offended someone by accident, by saying no the wrong way?

When is it hard for you to say no at work?

Have you ever agreed to something you didn't want to do? What happened?

How do you say no to your boss without sounding rude?

A close friend asks for a big favour. How do you turn them down?

Is it OK to say no to a customer? How would you do it?

Do you find it easier to say no in Chinese or in English? Why?

When someone says no to you, what makes it easier to accept?

What is a polite way to say no without giving a reason?